Government of India refused to pay me even after my return from Princeton University.

Rao said he was discussing with Sarabhai how he was being crucified for nothing. Sarabhai had assured him that he would make it official that Rao had taken the equipment home officially. 'I will take care of it,' Rao quoted Sarabhai as saying. 'It's eleven, and I have to catch up on sleep before my early morning walk.' And Rao left the place a relieved man. The next morning, he was to wake up with the double shock of having lost his boss and the prospects of facing charges of theft.

'Sarabhai was the only man who knew I was innocent,' Rao told me, crying. 'And now he is no more, I will die a thief.'

Rao wasn't wrong. He was suspended, transferred and persecuted. He died an unhappy man.

Theories abounded about Sarabhai's death, and I found it only natural for people to talk of such an unnatural death. A 52-year-old man of many virtues and virtually no vice, dropping dead on his bed after a perfectly happy night in a hotel room. I knew Sarabhai never smoked or drank. Many who had seen him at parties, which he used to network rather than shake a leg, moving around with a glass in his hand, probably didn't know that it was a diplomatic show. I had watched closely several times to catch Sarabhai take a sip at least at the end of the party, but that was never to be. He was health conscious and went on regular morning walks. And without a postmortem done on his body, the cause of his death would remain disputable, if not unknown.

THE REAL MISSILE MAN

Vikram Sarabhai is rightly known as the father of Indian space science. And by virtue of India's early attempts to project itself as an aspiring space power for peaceful purposes—TERLS being dedicated to the UN in February 1968 was seen by some as a step in this direction, though Sarabhai was clear about the benefits of exposure and learning opportunities India would get by keeping TERLS accessible to other space agencies—Sarabhai